of Fire) Scheme by the PMO, with the soldiers, sailors and airmen recruited under this scheme to be known as 'Agniveers' (Fire Warriors). The implication being that these are the young men and women who have been tested under the toughest of conditions and are ready to face all challenges in the service of the nation.

The AG's Branch under Lt Gen Arvind Datta and later Lt Gen Harsha Gupta, ably assisted by Brig (now Maj Gen) Shehrawat, came up with a number of models to implement the scheme. The first issue to be addressed was the issue of retention. We felt that it should be 75 per cent retention and 25 per cent released, the DMA felt it should be 50–50 per cent, with the term being five years. This was the model that was presented by the CDS to a full panel comprising the PM, Ministers of Home, Defence and Finance, NSA, Service Chiefs, PS to the PM and the Secretaries of the relevant departments in November 2020. In fact, it was during this meeting that the terms 'Agnipath' and 'Agniveer' were used for the first time. Assuming an intake of 50,000 soldiers each year, then after each 'tour', 25,000 soldiers would revert to civil society. It was felt that this was too little to bring about any significant change in the population, since one of the aims of the scheme was to give back to society disciplined manpower, who would be in a position to contribute much more in the workplace due to the values and ethos they would have imbibed while in Service. The percentages therefore got reversed, with only 25 per cent to be retained and 75 per cent released. It was back to the drawing board.

As the discussion progressed, the next issue that came up was the modalities for retention. It was taken for granted that this would be like the SSC scheme, with the retention or release after the contracted period of five years. On this account, the PMO view was that there should be a two-step retention

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